As with so many religious rebels, who disliked all sects and went their own ways, Kabir's fans responded by forming a sect in his name, Kabir Panth (Path of Kabir), now with centres all across India and even abroad. It is led by Kabir Math, located in a part of Varanasi called Kabir Chaura, where Kabir grew up. Adjoining the math's compound is the tomb of his parents, Niru and Nima. I spend a pleasant afternoon hour with Sant Vivek Das, the head of Kabir Math, who speaks about the genius of Kabir, his life and times, and his changing reception today. I ask if he agreed with Varanasi's popular image as a stronghold of Brahminism. He replies defiantly, 'A city that produced and still loves revolutionaries like Kabir and Ravidas is not a city of Brahminism, but one that belongs to people of all creeds and classes.'

Varanasi's past abounds in such sociopolitical contestations. Take the utopian visions of two other influential bhakti poet-thinkers of Varanasi from the fifteenth and sixteenth centuries: Ravidas and Tulsidas. Ravidas, an 'untouchable', advocated social reform towards a casteless and classless society he called 'Begumpura'—ideas that later animated B.R. Ambedkar. Whereas Tulsidas, a Brahmin, advocated personal piety and the status-quoist Varnashrama Dharma of 'Ram Rajya', where all castes adhered to their respective dharmas—ideas that later inspired M.K. Gandhi. Sensing a kindred spirit in me, Das speaks openly about the grave threat that Hindutva nationalism poses to Kabir's teachings. He has made it his life's work to defend and spread them. I browse and purchase two books on Kabir from a shop at the math and leave reflecting on this verse by him and the disguises under which I live my own life:[8]

> Dropped from the belly at birth,
> a man puts on his costumes
> and goes through his acts.

The Antiquity of Varanasi

Varanasi's high perch lies between two rivers (now mere streams): Varana in the north and Asi in the south. No points for guessing the origins of the city's name. To its east flows the Ganga, which here happens to flow north in its meandering course to the sea. Among the world's oldest living cities, perhaps as old as Jerusalem, Athens and Beijing, Varanasi ('Baranasi' in